

The Ob-Irtysh

A major river system of northwest Asia, crossing through some of the most remote and least populated regions on Earth



The Ob-Irtysh river system is a combination of two major Asian rivers that have their sources on different sides of the Altai Mountains (see p.224) and flow north, through the Siberian lowlands, to the Arctic Ocean.

Freezing and floods

Measuring a total of 3,460 miles (5,568km) from the source of the Irtysh to the mouth of the Ob, the river system is the longest in Siberia. Its catchment area is similar in size to the huge Mississippi-Missouri basin (see p.53). In its lower reaches, the river becomes braided across a vast, swampy plain that is subject to seasonal freezing and floods. The Ob-Irtysh empties through the Gulf of Ob, the world's longest estuary.

▷ ICE FLOES

The Ob-Irtysh starts to freeze in the fall from its mouth, in the north, southward. For more than half of the year, it is icebound and unnavigable.



The Lena

An epic trans-Siberian waterway, draining one-fifth of Russia's territory

One of the three great Siberian rivers, along with the Ob-Irtysh and Yenisei, the Lena flows 2,700 miles (4,400km) from its source in the Baikal Mountains, just west of Lake Baikal (see pp.238–39), across Siberia to its mouth in the Laptev Sea (an arm of the Arctic Ocean). The Lena has one of the largest basins in the world, draining one-fifth of Russia's territory. In its lower reaches, it is free of ice for only 4–5 months each year, following seasonal flooding.

At its mouth, the river forms the largest delta in the Arctic and the second largest on Earth. Spanning 170 miles (280km) and pushing out 70 miles (120km) into the ocean, it comprises lakes, channels, sandbars, and islands, with extensive peat bogs. In winter, it is a harsh wilderness, but in spring it supports millions of migratory birds.



◁ THE LENA PILLARS

The limestone of these rock pillars lining the banks of the Lena in the Sakha Republic was formed in a sea basin around 500 million years ago.